The Satti Family Tree

Oct 7, 2026 · @Mo

Summary

Your father's family belongs to the holy family of **Suwar al-Dhahab** ("Golden Bracelet") of Old Dongola and al-Ghaddar, the village beside it. The founder, Shaykh Muhammad son of 'Isa, was a Qur'an teacher and judge in the 1600s. He was also called **Satti Muhammad**. Satti has been a common name in the family ever since, and your surname comes from it.

How sure each part is:

- **Written records (documented):** the top five generations, from Salih al-Badiri down to Shaykh Ziyada and Hilali. They come from the *Tabaqat* of Wad Dayf Allah and from letters found by archaeologists at Old Dongola.
- **A printed family genealogy (tradition):** the later branches of the Ziyadab, your clan. 'Awn al-Sharif Qasim's encyclopedia of Sudanese tribes reprints a genealogy compiled by Shaykh Satti Ziyada Satti Hamad. It names a **Khabir son of Salih** and a branch living at **Binna**: the two names you remembered.
- **Family memory only:** your own chain, Hassan → Khabir → Hassan → Satti Mohamed → Mohamed Osman → Kamal → you. No record yet joins it to the tree. The missing stretch runs from about 1700 to about 1860.

What this round of research found:

- The three houses of al-Ghaddar, the **Ziyadab**, **Sawarab** and **Halalab**, all descend from the one founder. "Sawarab on the father's side, Ziyadab through a mother" therefore describes two branches of one family, not two clans.
- **"Bina" is very probably Banna**, an island and village about 30 km north of Dongola town. The printed genealogy places a Ziyadab branch there.
- The closest published match to your great-grandfather "Satti Mohamed son of Hassan" is **Satti Muhammad "al-Qadi" son of Hasan**, founder of the Qadiyab sub-house at Tangasi and al-Ghaddar. His probable brother, Surkati son of Hasan, founded a Ziyadab Surkati family. That fits your family's memory of a Surkati cousin of your grandfather. It is still unproven.
- By 'Awn's genealogy, Field Marshal Swar al-Dahab's branch is Ziyadab by descent. Shaykh Satti Majid's line runs through Hilali instead.
- Your father is the forester **Kamal Mohamed Osman Satti**, who wrote forestry and fuelwood reports in Khartoum in 1985–86. You have confirmed this.

The founding line

The family descends from Shaykh Muhammad son of ʿIsa son of Salih al-Badiri, called **Suwar al-Dhahab** ("Golden Bracelet"), a Qurʾan teacher and judge at Old Dongola in the early and middle 1600s. The *Tabaqat* of Wad Dayf Allah, the main biographical dictionary of Sudanese holy men, gives the first four generations by name.

Generation	Person	What the sources say	Status
1	Salih al-Badiri	Of the Bedairiya, Dahmashiya section.	Tradition
2	Shaykh ʿIsa son of Salih	One of the forty leading pupils of ʿAbd al-Rahman ibn Jabir (*Tabaqat* no. 144). A Bedairiya genealogy gives his death as 1070 AH (about 1660).	Documented
3	Shaykh Muhammad "Satti" Suwar al-Dhahab	Son of ʿIsa; his mother was Haqiqa (*Tabaqat* no. 191). Married a daughter of King Hasan, son of King Qashqash of Dongola. Buried at Dongola. A letter excavated in the king's house at Old Dongola names him (*Azania*, 2025). The Polish archaeological team dates his appointment as judge to 1095 AH (1683/84), which is probably too late (see Dates below).	Documented
4	Hilali son of Muhammad	His mother was the king's daughter (*Tabaqat* no. 134). Al-Ghaddar tradition makes him the ancestor of the **Halalab**.	Documented (the clan link is tradition)

Generation	Person	What the sources say	Status
4	al-Nur son of Muhammad	Known only as Ziyada's father. That this Muhammad is Suwar al-Dhahab is a strong inference, not stated in the *Tabaqat*.	Inference
5	Shaykh Ziyada son of al-Nur	Died at Old Dongola; his tomb was visited for blessings; succeeded by his son Ahmad (*Tabaqat* no. 259). A "Sheikh Zyad" tomb is still visited at Old Dongola. Al-Ghaddar tradition names a Ziyada as ancestor of the **Ziyadab**, your father's clan.	Documented (the links are inference and tradition)
6	Ahmad son of Ziyada	Succeeded his father.	Documented
6	Satti son of Ziyada	Settled at Mashu, north of Dongola, by a local history.	Tradition

Dates. *Al-Sharq al-Awsat* says the founder reached Sudan in 1504, and the Field Marshal repeated that date in 2010. The *Tabaqat* shows him already teaching before about 1615: one of his child pupils received a teaching licence dated 1030 AH (1621). One of his pupils was made a judge before about 1611. A King Badi of Sennar issued a charter protecting his students; this was probably Badi I (about 1611–16), possibly Badi II (1644–81). The Ottoman traveller Evliya Çelebi saw his tomb in the 1670s. He was therefore active from before 1611 into the 1620s, and died before the 1670s (my inference). Both the 1504 arrival and the 1683/84 appointment are probably wrong.

"Ancestor of the hundred." The nickname (ten sons, a hundred grandsons) belongs to Muhammad Suwar al-Dhahab himself; al-Masid and 'Awn al-Sharif Qasim both say so. One sentence in Abu Shouk can be read as giving it to 'Isa. No source names all ten sons.

Sources: *Tabaqat* electronic text; MacMichael's translation of the *Tabaqat* in *A History of the Arabs in the Sudan*, vol. 2 (entries 66, 134, 144, 191, 259); *Azania* 2026, "The King of Nubia at work"; Abu Shouk on Satti Majid.

What the family taught and practised

A judge of the time summed up the founder's legacy: he "brought the Qur'anic sciences and the science of *tawhid* (theology) to the Gezira, and initiated into the Path and guided." *(Tabaqat, entry on Ya'qub b. Mujalli.)* Unless marked otherwise, everything below is from the *Tabaqat* of Wad Dayf Allah.

Law and judging. Shaykh 'Isa taught his son the standard handbook of Maliki law, the *Mukhtasar* of Khalil: "one and a half readings, up to the chapter on funerals." When 'Isa died, his son took over his teaching circle. The founder served as qadi and "ruled by what is agreed upon and the stronger view among disputed ones." His son Hilali, also a judge, was known for steering property disputes toward a settlement rather than a verdict. *(Documented.)*

Theology and logic. The founder studied creeds, logic and the Qur'anic sciences with a Cairo-trained scholar, al-Misri, at Berber, and taught theology to pupils who passed it on. *(Documented.)*

The Qur'an. He taught memorisation and correct recitation (*tajwid*) to named pupils, among them 'Isa walad Kanu, 'Abdallah al-Aghbash (who founded the Qur'an schools at Berber) and Nasr al-Tarjami. Through them, "tajwid spread through the Gezira" for at least three generations, using standard teaching poems such as al-Jazariyya. *(Documented.)* Family tradition says he brought the **al-Duri reading** of the Qur'an to Sudan. That was the usual reading in Sudan's Qur'an schools, but no source before a 2010 interview with the Field Marshal names it in connection with the family. *(Tradition.)*

The Sufi path. He received initiation, from al-Misri by his own entry or from a teacher from Tlemcen by the book's introduction, and guided disciples of his own. The *Tabaqat* calls his path only "the Way of the Folk" and names no order. A family tradition of a Shadhili link through his mother conflicts with the record. *(Documented, apart from the tradition noted.)*

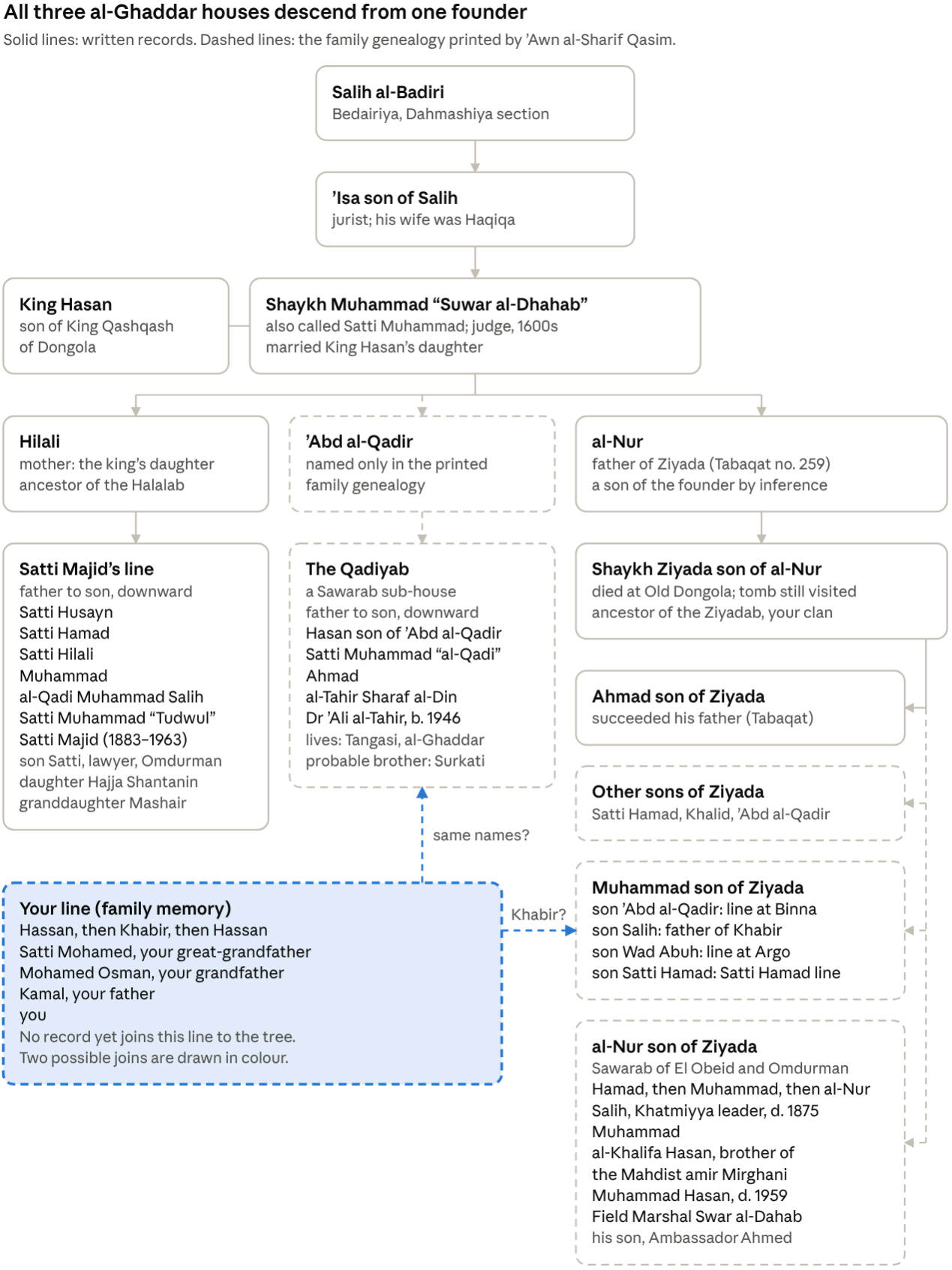
The Qur'an school. Ziyada, your clan's ancestor, was the founder's deputy "over the fire of the Qur'an", the night study-fire of the school. A Funj king put everyone who studied with the founder under protection, "their homes and their persons", and this was "still in force" around 1805. Students were fed and housed. By Ziyada's son Ahmad's time the school was rich enough to send a ship of goods downriver each year, and it lasted "until the ruin of the town". People visited Ziyada's tomb to pray for rain. *(Documented.)*

Into modern times. In the 1800s Salih Suwar al-Dhahab, of Ziyada's line, travelled with Muhammad 'Uthman al-Mirghani, founder of the Khatmiyya Sufi order, from Dongola to El Obeid and became one of his deputies (*khalifas*) there. A second Ziyadab man, Ziyada b. al-Faqih Ab, was also one of al-Mirghani's khalifas. The El Obeid branch held the title of khalifa down to the Field Marshal's father; the Field Marshal inherited the seat but did not

exercise it. Some family members fought as Mahdist commanders in 1882–98. Satti Majid studied at Shaykh 'Awad's Qur'an school in al-Ghaddar before al-Azhar, and later headed the family's religious seat there. *(Documented; the Field Marshal's seat is family testimony.)*

Stories told about the founder. In a famine he turned palm fronds into silver for the hungry; he "ruled the seven kings of the jinn"; dying, he sent his royal wife to the disciple 'Awuda, who seated the boy Hilali on his prayer-mat and said: "I have seated you in your father's place." *(Hagiography.)*

The full tree



The Suwar al-Dhahab house · the founder, three houses, and where your line may join

The founder's sons formed three houses at al-Ghaddar. The drawing shows every line that later sources attach to them. In the boxes marked "father to son, downward", each line is one generation.

The founder was remembered as "father of ten" (ten sons, a hundred grandsons), but only three sons are named anywhere: Hilali, al-Nur and 'Abd al-Qadir.

Branch	Descends from	Where they live	Named members	How sure
Halalab	Hilali, son of the founder and King Hasan's daughter	al-Ghaddar, Bukkibul, al-Ghaba	Satti Majid's line; the imam of al-Ghaddar, Sheikh Mohamed Sati Babiker Hilali	Documented down to Satti Majid. The imam is placed by his name only
Ziyadab	Shaykh Ziyada son of al-Nur	al-Ghaddar, Old Dongola, Mashu, Banna, Argo	Sons Ahmad, al-Nur, Satti Hamad, Khalid, 'Abd al-Qadir and Muhammad	Ziyada and Ahmad documented; the other sons come from the printed genealogy
Ziyadab of Binna	'Abd al-Qadir son of Muhammad son of Ziyada	Banna island and Gharb Banna, north of Dongola town	Descendants not named	Tradition
Khabir's family	Salih son of Muhammad son of Ziyada	Not stated	Sons Ziyada, 'Isa, Muhammad, **Khabir**, 'Abd al-Rahim and al-Fiki	Tradition
Ziyadab of Argo	Wad Abuh son of Muhammad son of Ziyada	Bigiyu (Kiyu), Argo	Not named	Tradition

Branch	Descends from	Where they live	Named members	How sure
Satti Hamad line	Satti Hamad son of Muhammad son of Ziyada	Not stated	In the 1900s: Ziyada Satti Hamad (undersecretary of the Interior), Khabir Satti Hamad, and Shaykh Satti Ziyada Satti Hamad, who compiled the genealogy	Tradition
Ziyadab of Mashu	Shaykh Ziyada, by local history	Mashu island	Shaykh Wad ʻIsa Ziyada (teacher of President Nimeiri), Dr Ziyada ʻAbdallah Ziyada	Tradition
Sawarab of El Obeid and Omdurman	al-Nur son of Ziyada	El Obeid; Wad Nubawi, Omdurman	Salih (d. 1875), the Mahdist amir Mirghani, al-Khalifa Hasan, the Field Marshal and his children	Lower generations documented; the link up to Ziyada is tradition
Qadiyab, a Sawarab sub-house	Satti Muhammad "al-Qadi" son of Hasan son of ʻAbd al-Qadir	Tangasi, al-Ghaddar, al-Ghaba	Dr ʻAli al-Tahir Sharaf al-Din (born 1946, physicist)	Tradition
King's line	King Qashqash, then King Hasan, then his daughter, the founder's wife	al-Ghaddar, Bukkibul, al-Ghaba	Their descendants are writing a family history (*Azania*, 2026)	Documented

In the house but not yet placed:

- **Satti wad ʻIsa** (about 1750–1810), called "ancestor of the Ziyadab". His daughter ʻA'isha was the mother of Muhammad Hammur (1822–82), a district governor under Turco-Egyptian rule.

- **Sheikh Sati Hamid Suwar al-Dahab**, who restored the Old Dongola mosque in the late 1700s. His descendants in al-Ghaddar still look after his tomb.
- **Hussein Satti Mohamed**, the last imam of the Old Dongola mosque, which closed in 1969. His father's name, Satti Mohamed, is the same as your great-grandfather's.
- **Sati Muhammad Muhammad Ziada** and **Khalifa Muhammad Hasan Sati**, who signed a Dongola family pedigree printed by MacMichael in 1922.

Your direct line

This is the chain as your family recites it, with the closest matches the sources offer. The birth dates are my estimates, about 30 years a generation.

Generation	Name	Born (estimate)	Closest match in the sources	Status
You	Mohamed Kamal Satti			Family memory
Father	Kamal	1900s	A forester named **Kamal Mohamed Osman Satti** wrote a charcoal-kiln report in Khartoum (1985) and two FAO fuelwood papers (1986). You have confirmed he is your father	Documented (confirmed by you)

Generation	Name	Born (estimate)	Closest match in the sources	Status
Grandfather	Mohamed Osman	about 1890–1930	**Ustadh Mohamed Osman Satti**, an educator in Wad Madani: headmaster at al-Sireiha and author of 16 children's books. Known only from a newspaper column that gives no parents. A 2008 forum post says that man was then living in Wad Madani, so he is not your grandfather. Family memory: your grandfather died in the 1980s and married twice, first another wife and then Zahara, your grandmother; your father has half-sisters from the first marriage	A different man
Great-grandfather	Satti Mohamed (probably one name)	about 1860–90	**Satti Muhammad "al-Qadi" son of Hasan**, founder of the Qadiyab. Several other men of the period had this common name	Name match only
2× great-grandfather	Hassan	about 1830–60		Family memory

Generation	Name	Born (estimate)	Closest match in the sources	Status
3× great-grandfather	Khabir (you wrote Haber)	about 1800–30	**Khabir son of Salih son of Muhammad son of Shaykh Ziyada**, the only Khabir in any Ziyadab genealogy	Name match only
4× great-grandfather	Hassan, or Salih	about 1770–1810	You first remembered "Khabir, Salih". The printed genealogy's Khabir is a son of Salih	Unsettled

Two ways your line could join the tree. Neither is proven. The family can test both.

1. **Through Khabir and Binna (the Ziyadab).** If your Khabir is Khabir son of Salih, your line runs: Shaykh Ziyada → Muhammad → Salih → Khabir → Hassan → Satti Mohamed → Mohamed Osman → Kamal → you. This fits three things the family said: the name Khabir, the name Salih, and the clan name Ziyadab. The same printed genealogy places Khabir's cousins at Binna, which fits your family's "Bina". The problem is timing. That Khabir probably lived in the 1700s, two or three generations before the family's Khabir. Recited chains often skip generations, so missing names may sit between them.
2. **Through the Qadiyab.** Satti Muhammad "al-Qadi" son of Hasan matches your "Satti Mohamed son of Hassan" exactly, and he was born about the right time. The problem: his grandfather is 'Abd al-Qadir, not Khabir. The Surkati story makes this the stronger of the two (see below).

The strongest lead: Satti Muhammad and his brother Surkati. 'Awn's encyclopedia names two men with the same father and grandfather:

- **Satti Muhammad "al-Qadi" son of Hasan son of 'Abd al-Qadir**, founder of the Qadiyab of Tangasi, al-Ghaddar and al-Ghaba.
- **Surkati son of Hasan son of 'Abd al-Qadir**, "of the Ziyadab". His sons were al-Khalifa Abu Bakr and Muqbil Surkati, and Abu Bakr's son was Professor Yusuf al-Khalifa Abubakr Surkati (born 1927).

They were very probably brothers (my inference; no source says so directly). If your great-grandfather Satti Mohamed son of Hassan is this Satti Muhammad, then Abu Bakr and Muqbil Surkati were your grandfather's first cousins. That matches what your family remembers: a Surkati who was your grandfather's cousin. It would also join your line to the Ziyadab, the clan your chain ends in.

The one conflict is Hassan's father, whom the family calls Khabir and the encyclopedia calls 'Abd al-Qadir. Both names sit in the same part of the printed Ziyadab genealogy: an 'Abd al-Qadir whose line lived at Binna, and his nephew Khabir son of Salih.

About the family story. Family memory says a Suwar al-Dhahab ancestor married many times, and his children took their mothers' clan names, Sawarab or Ziyadab. No written source tells this story. It fits the facts, though: both houses come from the same founder, so a child of either could carry either name.

"Bina" is very probably Banna. No village called Bina exists near Old Dongola. Banna is an island and village (Gharb Banna) in the Argo stretch of the Nile, about 30 km north of Dongola town. Several Satti families are rooted there and nearby.

What the DNA says

You and your father tested with 23andMe. The results below are as you reported them; the readings are from published genetic studies.

Line	Result	Whose line it is	What it means
Male line (Y chromosome)	**E-M78**, the same for you and your father	The Satti father-to-son line	A northeast African lineage about 15,000–20,000 years old, thought to have arisen in Egypt or northern Sudan and common along the Sudanese Nile

Line	Result	Whose line it is	What it means
Your father's maternal line (mtDNA)	**L2a1**	Your grandmother Zahara's mother-to-mother line	The main branch of L2a, one of Africa's most widespread maternal lines; L2a1 is roughly 16,000–34,000 years old by different estimates. Sudan is an L2a hotspot (about 16–30% in Sudanese samples). At medieval Kulubnarti, 16 of 66 people carried L2a1, the commonest African maternal branch there
Your father's overall mix	48% Middle Eastern & North African, 48% Sub-Saharan (mostly East African), 2% European	All his ancestors	Typical of riverine northern Sudanese: studies put Nubians and Sudanese Arab groups at about 40–48% Eurasian-related ancestry

Reading the male line.

- Many men from Arabian male lines carry J1, and J1 is common among Sudanese Arabic speakers. Your line is E-M78, so the Satti male line is most likely northeast African in deep origin (inference). That does not overturn the family's Arab genealogy, which can run through other ancestors or through a family joining a lineage.
- In Christian Nubia, at the Kulubnarti cemetery (about 650–1000 AD), 17 of 30 men carried E1b1b, the branch E-M78 belongs to; 12 of 28 unrelated men carried lines of likely Eurasian origin. Your male line looks like the Nubian majority of that time (Sirak et al. 2021).
- E-M78 splits into regional branches such as E-V12, E-V22 and E-V32. Your 23andMe raw data may place you on one of them.

When the mixing happened. Studies date the Eurasian mixing among the Danagla to roughly 1,000–1,600 years ago, in the Christian era or earlier, and among Sudanese Arab groups to about 700 years ago, around the fall of Christian Dongola in 1315–17. Treat these

as broad ranges.

A DNA test of the family tree. If a man from the Qadiyab of Tangasi or the Ziyadab Surkati family took a full Y-chromosome test, such as FamilyTreeDNA's Big Y-700, and you or your father did too, the result would settle the question. A shared recent branch with only a few differences would confirm a common male ancestor within the last few centuries; the fewer the differences, the closer he lived. A different major branch would rule the link out. Whether any such man has tested is unknown.

Sources: Sirak et al. 2021, *Nature Communications*; Hollfelder et al. 2017, *PLoS Genetics*; Hammarén et al. 2023, *PLoS One*; Vilà-Valls et al. 2026, *PNAS*; Silva et al. 2015, *Scientific Reports*; Hassan et al. 2008, *American Journal of Physical Anthropology*; 23andMe Ancestry Composition Guide (2025).

Recent and living relatives

Most public figures named Satti or Suwar al-Dhahab come from the same al-Ghaddar holy family, but no published record yet joins them to your own chain. The relation column is my best estimate from the generations.

Person	Dates	Place in the family	Likely relation to you	Source
Shaykh Satti Majid Muhammad al-Qadi Suwar al-Dhahab	1883–1963	Of al-Ghaddar. His father is called Ziyadab, but his recorded male line runs through Hilali (the Halalab); imam in the USA 1904–29; head of the family's religious seat	A cousin of your great-grandfather's generation	Documented
Amna 'Awad 'Uthman	20th c.	Satti Majid's wife	—	Documented
Hajja Shantanin bint Satti Majid	20th c.	His daughter, of al-Ghaddar	Distant cousin, your grandparents' generation	Documented

Person	Dates	Place in the family	Likely relation to you	Source
Satti son of Satti Majid	20th c.	His son, a lawyer in al-Thawra, Omdurman, per the researcher ʻAbd al-Hamid Muhammad Ahmad	Distant cousin	Reported
Shaykh Muhammad Ahmad al-Qadi	20th c.	Satti Majid's sister's son	Distant cousin	Documented
Mashair Suwar al-Dhahab	20th–21st c.	Satti Majid's granddaughter, of al-Ghaddar; married the swimmer Sultan Kigab	Distant cousin, about your parents' generation	Documented
Sati Mohamed Sati and Sheikh Mohamed Sati Babiker	living, 2019–21	A former teacher and the imam of al-Ghaddar, interviewed by archaeologists	Probably cousins through the al-Ghaddar houses	Documented
Field Marshal ʻAbd al-Rahman Swar al-Dahab	1934 or 1935–2018	Sawarab of El Obeid and Omdurman, a Ziyadab line by ʻAwn's genealogy. Al-Nilin calls his mother Hajja al-Sarira Satti; ʻAwn and Asharq al-Awsat name her al-Sarira bint Mahdi Dayf Allah, whose mother Hurum was a Ziyadab. Born in Wad Nubawi, Omdurman	Distant cousin, twice removed	Documented
Ahmed Abdel-Rahman Swar al-Dahab	living	The Field Marshal's son; ambassador to Qatar 2022–25	Distant cousin, once removed	Documented

Person	Dates	Place in the family	Likely relation to you	Source
al-Khalifa Abubakr Muhammad Ziyada Mirghani Swar al-Dhahab	living, 2018	Religious leader of al-Sururab, north of Omdurman	Sawarab relative; exact link unknown	Documented
Mirghani Swar al-Dhahab	19th c.	The Mahdist amir Mirghani (born 1860), brother of the Field Marshal's grandfather, led the Danagla Sawarab at the fall of Khartoum in 1885. An "Ostadh Mirghani", a Khatmiyya head, signed a Dongola pedigree printed by MacMichael; they may be the same man	Cousin of your ancestors' generation	Documented

Satti families that are separate lines. These share the name, and some the region, but no source links them to the Suwar al-Dhahab house:

- Ambassador Nureldin Satti, son of Dr Mohamed Hamad Satti (born 1910). That family moved from Old Dongola to Metemma and then Shendi.
- Journalist Hassan Satti (1948–2008), son of al-Hajj Satti Mohamed al-Tahir, of al-Afad near Old Dongola: the same Bedairiya clan, a different line.
- Dr Satti Hassan Satti, a Northern State health official in Dongola; no genealogy found.
- Mohamed Osman Satti, an educator in Wad Madani. His name matches your grandfather's, but he seems to have been alive around 2013, after your grandfather died in the 1980s.
- Awad Satti (born 1901, al-Duwaim) is an unrelated line.

The Surkati connection

Your family says a Surkati, a cousin of your grandfather, went to Indonesia and Malaysia to teach Islam and built a mosque in Indonesia. The records name several Surkatis who fit parts of this, and show two ways the name ties to your family.

Shaykh Ahmad Surkati and his brother Satti (documented)

- **Shaykh Ahmad Muhammad Surkati al-Ansari** was born in 1875 at Udfu, a village on Argo island north of Dongola. He studied in Mecca and Medina and went to Java in 1911. In 1914 he founded the al-Irshad movement, which opened about 30 schools. He learned Dutch and Malay, died in Batavia (Jakarta) in 1943, and had no children.
- His younger full brother, **Abu al-Fadl Muhammad Satti al-Ansari**, graduated from Gordon College in Khartoum in 1911 and joined him in Java in 1912. He opened and ran the al-Irshad school in Surabaya and taught in Tegal. He died in Jakarta on 16 October 1944. The Surkati family still living in Indonesia descends from him.
- A nephew, a brother's son who came to Java aged 14, also taught there; 'Awn names a "Shaykh Siddiq Surkati, his brother's son" among the teachers. His descendants married into al-Irshad families, and some still live in Indonesia.
- This family calls itself Ansari, descended from the Prophet's companion Jabir son of 'Abd Allah, and comes from Argo and Maqasir islands. Their name comes from an ancestor four generations back who brought home many books from Egypt; in Dongolawi, "surkati" is said to mean "many books".

Surkatis inside the Ziyadab (from 'Awn's encyclopedia)

- The printed Ziyadab genealogy lists a **Hajj Surkati** among the sons of Satti Hamad son of Muhammad son of Shaykh Ziyada. One branch of that family lived at Bigiyu in Argo.
- **Surkati son of Hasan son of 'Abd al-Qadir**, "of the Ziyadab", married Kulthum, a great-great-granddaughter of Satti Hamad. Their sons were **al-Khalifa Abu Bakr** and **Muqbil Surkati**. Abu Bakr married Nafisa, daughter of Hamid Muhammad Bey of the Hakimab of Argo. Their son, **Professor Yusuf al-Khalifa Abubakr Surkati** (born 1927), studied in Omdurman, Cairo, Michigan and Manchester and became registrar of Omdurman Islamic University and later minister of Religious Affairs. Nafisa's brother, Shaykh Hasan Hamid, joined Ahmad Surkati in Indonesia in 1913 and died there in 1954.
- **Muhammad 'Abd al-Rahman Surkati**, "of the Ziyadab, the Sawarab", was a government clerk whose children lived in Omdurman.

A Surkati in Malaysia (lead). 'Awn says that Ahmad al-'Aqib Shukrallah, one of Ahmad Surkati's teachers in Indonesia, later went to Malaysia "with the two shaykhs **al-Jilani Surkati** and al-'Abbasi" and founded an Islamic school there. This is the only Surkati recorded in Malaysia. His parents are not named.

Who fits "a cousin of my grandfather". Your grandfather Mohamed Osman was probably born between about 1890 and 1930. The best fit is **al-Khalifa Abu Bakr Surkati or his brother Muqbil**. Their father, Surkati son of Hasan son of 'Abd al-Qadir, was very probably a brother of Satti Muhammad son of Hasan son of 'Abd al-Qadir, the closest match to your great-grandfather (see *Your direct line*). Abu Bakr's brother-in-law went to teach in Indonesia with Ahmad Surkati in 1913. That could explain why the family links "Surkati"

with Indonesia. Ahmad Surkati himself (born 1875) and his brother Satti belong to your great-grandfather's generation. The nephew who arrived aged 14 and al-Jilani Surkati in Malaysia are your grandfather's age, but no record ties them to your family.

The mosque. No source checked so far says that any Surkati built a mosque in Indonesia or Malaysia. Every biography describes schools and organisations instead: the first al-Irshad school opened in Batavia on 6 September 1914. A mosque called Masjid Al-Irsyad stands in Surabaya, where Satti ran the school, but its founder and date are not recorded in what I could reach. A further search is checking mosques linked to al-Irshad.

A possible source of the mosque story, in Sudan. The Old Dongola mosque at al-Ghaddar, a Christian throne hall turned into a mosque in 1317, is called the oldest standing mosque in Sudan, and popularly its first. Local tradition credits a Suwar al-Dhahab man, Sheikh Sati Hamid (also given as Satti Muhammad 'Isa), with a major restoration in the late 1700s. His descendants still look after his tomb. 'Awn's genealogy lists a **Hajj Surkati** among the sons of Satti Hamad son of Muhammad son of Shaykh Ziyada, so a Surkati sits inside the restorer's family. Over generations the family may have merged this story with the Surkatis who taught in Indonesia. This is my inference, and no source names a Surkati as the builder.

How sure this is. Ahmad Surkati's brother being named Satti is documented. So are the Ziyadab Surkati family and the Qadiyab founder, in 'Awn's encyclopedia. That Satti Muhammad and Surkati were brothers is my inference from their identical father and grandfather. That your great-grandfather is that Satti Muhammad is unproven. One idea can be ruled out: your great-grandfather is not Ahmad Surkati's brother Satti, whose father and grandfather were both named Muhammad.

Work, ambitions and character

For about 350 years the recorded work on this side is religious learning: teaching the Qur'an and law, judging, running a Qur'an school, keeping the Old Dongola mosque and leading a Sufi order. In the 20th century relatives took that calling into the army, law, diplomacy and missionary work abroad. Your father, a forester, is the first of your direct line with a recorded profession.

Era	Who	Work	Status
1600s	Shaykh 'Isa	Jurist; taught the Maliki law handbook *Mukhtasar Khalil* in a teaching circle	Documented

Era	Who	Work	Status
1610s–60s	Muhammad Suwar al-Dhahab	Judge (*qadi*); ran a residential Qur'an school at Old Dongola; taught doctrine, recitation and the Sufi path	Documented
Later 1600s	Hilali	Judge and teacher, "favoured among the Funj and the Arabs"	Documented
Later 1600s	Ziyada, ancestor of the Ziyadab	Ran the Qur'an school; a contemporary said "he has students"	Documented
1700s–1900s	The house at al-Ghaddar	Keepers of the Old Dongola mosque and the family tombs; heads of the family's religious seat	Tradition
1817–1875	Salih Suwar al-Dhahab	Khatmiyya Sufi leader at El Obeid; sons served as Mahdist commanders	Documented
1904–1963	Shaykh Satti Majid	Imam, missionary and founder of Muslim societies in England and the USA; later head of the family seat at al-Ghaddar	Documented
1900s	Muhammad Hasan Swar al-Dahab	Khatmiyya leader and Qur'an teacher in El Obeid	Documented
1950s–2018	Field Marshal Swar al-Dahab	Army officer; head of state 1985–86; chaired the Islamic Call Organization, which built schools	Documented
Late 1900s	Satti son of Satti Majid	Lawyer in Omdurman	Documented
2022–25	Ahmed Swar al-Dahab	Ambassador to Qatar	Documented
Today	Relatives in al-Ghaddar	Imams, a teacher, keepers of the mosque and tombs; farming below the old citadel	Documented

Era	Who	Work	Status
1985–86	Kamal Mohamed Osman Satti	Your father. A forester: he co-wrote a Khartoum charcoal-kiln report (1985) and two FAO fuelwood papers (1986)	Documented (confirmed by you)

What they aimed for.

- **The founder** wanted correct Qur'an recitation and doctrine to spread. His pupils carried it across the Gezira.
- **Satti Majid** wanted to defend Islam in public. In his own words: "When I found that publishing in the newspapers did no good, I began to treat the matter by spreading the pure religion." His 1928 Pittsburgh society aimed "to unite the Moslem people and eradicate racial differences due to their color and nationality." Late in life he pressed the government for better homes for relatives in Khartoum.
- **The Field Marshal** held himself to a fixed one-year transition: "I added only twenty days to that period so that the democratic elections could be completed." Later he put his effort into schools.

Character, from what people did and said. These belong to the individuals named, not to the family as a whole.

Trait	Who	Evidence	Status
Wise preacher; merciful to a repentant pupil	The founder	*Tabaqat*: "a man of wisdom and good exhortation"; he interceded for a pupil who had broken a promise	Documented, with hagiography
Tireless organiser; responsible for strangers	Satti Majid	In 1921 he wrote at least seven letters to British officials for stranded Yemeni and Indian sailors	Documented
Outspoken in defending his faith	Satti Majid	Told Noble Drew Ali "to burn the book he had concocted"	Documented
Self-promoting	Satti Majid	Called himself "Shaykh al-Islam in the United States" and claimed 45,000 converts; al-Azhar said he had appointed himself	Critics' opinion

Trait	Who	Evidence	Status
Dignified, generous, gentle	Satti Majid	The historian Muhammad 'Abd al-Rahim, who stayed with him in 1941	Eyewitness opinion
Forgiving; asked nothing for himself	Satti Majid	Said to have forgiven the man who stabbed him; refused a land grant for himself alone	Family memory
Reluctant to take power; kept his word	The Field Marshal	Took office "after great hesitation" and handed over on schedule	Documented
Simple and devout; kept up family ties	The Field Marshal	His grandson: "a simple man"; a kinsman: "the man who keeps up ties"	Family testimony
A disputed political record	The Field Marshal	Chaired the 2015 committee that renominated al-Bashir	Disputed

How the family changed over time.

- **Patrons:** in the 1600s their standing came from the kings of Dongola and Sennar; in the 1900s from the modern state, the army and international bodies.
- **Places:** from Old Dongola and al-Ghaddar to El Obeid, Omdurman, Khartoum and abroad. Branches kept their ties home: Satti Majid returned to head the family seat, and relatives still keep the tombs.
- **Work:** from scholars and judges to officers, lawyers, diplomats and, in your father, a forester.

Sources: the *Tabaqat* via MacMichael vol. 2; Abu Shouk, Hunwick and O'Fahey, *Sudanic Africa* 8 (1997); Abu Shouk on Sudanile; Satti Majid, Wikipedia; al-Nilin obituary of the Field Marshal; al-Quds al-Arabi.

Evidence: what is documented, what is tradition

Documented means a written record names the person. **Tradition** means a family genealogy or local history that no older record confirms yet. **Lead** means a name match that the family needs to confirm.

Claim	Status	Source
Muhammad son of ʿIsa son of Salih al-Badiri, "Suwar al-Dhahab", whose mother was Haqiqa, taught and judged at Dongola and was buried there	Documented	*Tabaqat* e-text; MacMichael vol. 2, nos. 144, 191
He was teaching before about 1615; a pupil's licence is dated 1621	Documented	*Tabaqat*, entry on Abu Malah
A letter found in the royal house at Old Dongola names "Muhammad son of ʿIsa son of Salih"	Documented	*Azania* 2025
Hilali's mother was a daughter of King Hasan son of Qashqash	Documented	*Tabaqat*; MacMichael nos. 66, 134; *Azania* 2026
Ziyada son of al-Nur son of Shaykh Muhammad walad ʿIsa died at Old Dongola; his son Ahmad and then Ahmad's son succeeded him	Documented	MacMichael no. 259; *Tabaqat*, 1930 edition
The Ziyadab, Sawarab and Halalab are the founding houses of al-Ghaddar	Tradition	Arabic Wikipedia, al-Ghaddar, from a single article
Khabir son of Salih son of Muhammad son of Ziyada; the line of ʿAbd al-Qadir son of Muhammad lives at Binna	Tradition	ʿAwn al-Sharif Qasim, vol. 2, entry "Ziyada"
The Qadiyab descend from Satti Muhammad "al-Qadi" son of Hasan son of ʿAbd al-Qadir	Tradition	ʿAwn, vol. 5, entry "Qadiyab"

Claim	Status	Source
Satti Majid's male line runs Satti Muhammad "Tudwul" → Muhammad Salih → Muhammad → Satti Hilali → Satti Hamad → Satti Husayn → Satti Hilali → the founder	Documented	al-Masid, p. 147, citing *al-Nida'* (1953)
Satti Majid was born at al-Ghaddar in 1883 and died on 17 March 1963; his father was of the Ziyadab section	Documented	*Sudanic Africa* 8 (1997)
The El Obeid and Omdurman Sawarab descend from Shaykh Ziyada through al-Nur, Hamad, Muhammad, al-Nur and Salih (died El Obeid 1875)	Tradition	'Awn, vols 1–3
Mirghani and Hasan were brothers; Hasan built the Sawarab mosque in Omdurman; the Field Marshal's mother was al-Sarira bint Mahdi Dayf Allah	Documented	*Asharq al-Awsat*, 27 April 2007
Satti wad 'Isa, "ancestor of the Ziyadab", was the maternal grandfather of Muhammad Hammur (born about 1822)	Tradition	'Awn, vol. 2, entry "Hammur"
Banna island and Gharb Banna lie about 30 km north of Dongola town; there is no Bina near Old Dongola	Documented	OpenStreetMap; Arabic Wikipedia, Dabla island
Hussein Satti Mohamed was the last imam of the Old Dongola mosque, closed in 1969	Documented	PCMA, *Old Dongola: Continuity and change* (2021)

Claim	Status	Source
Sheikh Mohamed Sati Babiker Hilali and Sheikh Abo Bakr Khalifa Mohamed Zyada are living knowledge holders in al-Ghaddar	Documented	*PAM* 34/2 (2025)
Around 1922 the family lived in Dongola and called themselves Bedairiya of the Dahmashiya section	Documented (their own claim)	MacMichael vol. 1, p. 177
A forester named Kamal Mohamed Osman Satti wrote reports in Khartoum in 1985–86	Documented; you confirmed he is your father	Open Library; FAO
Ustadh Mohamed Osman Satti was a headmaster and children's author in Wad Madani (probably not your grandfather, who died in the 1980s)	Lead	al-Rakoba column (the page would not open)
Your chain from the eldest Hassan down to you, and Khabir's many marriages	Family memory	No written source found

Open leads and the questions that would close them

The family can settle most of these. After them, a few named people and unread books are the best sources.

Questions for your family

1. Your father is confirmed as the forester Kamal Mohamed Osman Satti. Your grandfather died in the 1980s, so he is probably not the Wad Madani children's author, who seems to have been alive around 2013. Where did your grandfather live and work?
2. Who was Khabir's father, Hassan or Salih? Does anyone recite the names 'Abd al-Qadir or "al-Qadi", or mention the village of Tangasi?
3. Is "Bina" the island and village of Banna (Gharb Banna), north of Dongola town? Which relatives lived there?

4. Your grandmother was Zahara: whose daughter was she, and from which family? Who was Mohamed Osman's first wife? What were the names of Satti Mohamed's wife and of the Ziyadab woman whose clan name the line took? Who were Mohamed Osman's own brothers and sisters?
5. Did your great-grandfather Satti Mohamed have a brother named Surkati? Did your grandfather have cousins called al-Khalifa Abu Bakr Surkati or Muqbil Surkati, or know Professor Yusuf al-Khalifa Abubakr? Which mosque in Indonesia does the family mean, and in which town?

New leads on your grandfather's family (October 2026)

- **Mustafa Moh. Osman Satti.** A 1953 directory lists him as secretary of the Ahlia Elementary School Teachers' Trade Union, at the Deims non-government school in Khartoum. Read the Sudanese way, he is Mustafa son of Mohamed Osman Satti. If his father was your grandfather, Mustafa would be an older half-brother of your father from the first marriage. Lead only: other men had the same name. *(Europa, The Middle East, 1953; seen as a snippet.)*
- **Ahmed Khabier Satti.** He wrote a 1970 MSc dissertation in pharmacology at Bradford and published from Bradford in 1972 and 1989. His name reads as Ahmed son of Khabir son of Satti. He may be a son of Khabir Satti Hamad of the Ziyadab, or, if your grandfather had a brother Khabir, a first cousin of your father. *(Open Library; PubMed.)*
- **"Khabir" may be a title.** Around 1800 "al-Khabir" was also an honorific in the Dongola region, so your ancestor may have been known by a title rather than a name.
- **Ruled out:** the 1985 Saudi newspaper notice (it concerns a Mohamed Khidir Osman Satti) and the Wad Madani author (alive in 2012–16).

People who may know

- Ziyadab elders, and the family of Ziyada Satti Hamad. They may hold the written genealogy that 'Awn al-Sharif Qasim used, which is the only one with both a Khabir and a Binna branch.
- In al-Ghaddar: the imam, Sheikh Mohamed Sati Babiker Hilali; Sheikh Abo Bakr Khalifa Mohamed Zyada; and Sati Mohamed Sati, a former teacher and local historian.
- The Polish archaeologists' community project at Old Dongola (Tomomi Fushiya and Mohamed Hassan Siedahmed), which interviews al-Ghaddar families. King Qashqash's descendants are also writing a family history.
- The Qadiyab of Tangasi, through the family of Dr 'Ali al-Tahir Sharaf al-Din.
- Elders of Banna and Gharb Banna, who could say whether they remember a Khabir and his son Hassan.

Books and papers not yet read

- The written genealogy compiled by Shaykh Satti Ziyada Satti Hamad.

- Page 1158 of 'Awn's volume 3 (entry "Sawarab"). It is missing from every online scan and probably names more of the founder's sons.
- The Yusuf Fadl Hasan edition of the *Tabaqat*, for its notes on Ziyada, Hilali and al-Nur.
- 'Abd al-Hamid Muhammad Ahmad, *Shiyakhat al-Islam fi Amrika* (1978), and Muhammad 'Abd al-Rahim, *al-Nida' fi daf' al-iftira'* (1953), on Satti Majid's family.
- Sayf al-Din 'Isa Mukhtar, *Akalil al-Lujayn*, a local history of Mashu.

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Places and local history

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Leads on your own line

- Open Library: the 1985 charcoal report; FAO, Forestry development in Sudan, annex 7; al-Rakoba column on Mohamed Osman Satti